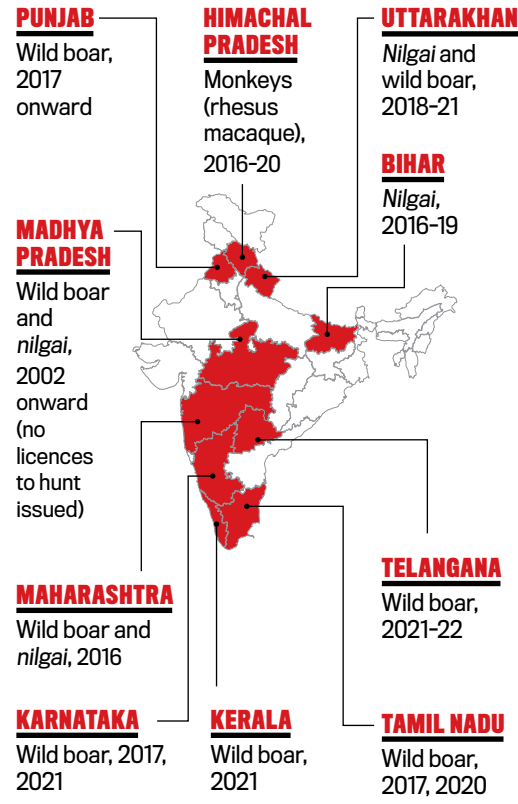


ANIMAL, PEST OR RESOURCE? Nilgai in Bulandshahr district, UP

PRASHANTH VISHWANATHAN/GETTY IMAGES

CULLING A HISTORY

In the past six years, at least 10 states across India have issued notifications declaring various species (mostly wild boar and *nilgai*) as 'vermin' to permit their culling. The practice continues



and the protections they get. Currently, there are six lists ('schedules') that mandate varying levels of protection, with Schedule I species having the most protection. When it comes to man-animal conflict, the government can designate any species—except those in Schedule I and some in II—as 'vermin' for a period of time. This permits hunting, the rationale being that a cull provides a short-term (if bloody) solution. The new proposals go further, permitting the government to declare even protected species as vermin. Some experts are in favour—Pabla, for one, describes the leopards of Mumbai and the Asiatic lions in rural Gujarat as potential vermin, since man-animal conflict threatens human life. He also argues for the creation of private wildlife reserves, in the hope that they will connect the existing fragmented government-owned reserves. Detractors, though, say privately-managed reserves could begin a shift toward commercial hunting, with licences and animal lives then being sold for profit.

Peter Smetacek, noted lepidopterist and founder of the Bhimtal-based Butterfly Research Centre, also supports the push to relax laws, saying the current WPA makes conflict worse. "The WPA makes people opposed to wildlife at places where there is intensified conflict," he says. "Before the WPA, India had a mosaic of wildlife laws, which is required in a country this large and diverse. A species may be found in abundance in one area but not in another habitat." Pointing out that the current system does not permit this nuance, he adds, "One cannot accurately describe a given species as 'endangered' or 'prolific' across the entire country, which is what the WPA [tries to do]."

Those opposed to hunting include Dr M.K. Ranjitsinh, who, as deputy secretary for wildlife at the then-Union ministry of agriculture, drafted the WPA, 1972. A former member of the national board for wildlife, Dr Ranjitsinh says hunting is anachronistic. "We were a nation of hunters, but the country and the world have moved on. The acceptability of hunting has diminished—there is a massive backlash now even when a man-eating carnivore is killed," he points out. He also highlights the fallibility of blanket laws, saying: "There is also a fundamental question involved in allowing hunting; are we [saying we have a] surplus of certain species? If we are at surplus in one place doesn't mean we are at surplus across the country."

He also addresses another common pro-hunting argument, that the commercial model used by countries in Africa could be applied in India to generate profit. "We cannot apply the African model in India mainly because we aren't a land-excess country," he says. "Also, the practical experience is that you can't have a halfway house in India. If you allow hunting, you risk losing everything [we have gained in terms of conservation], because implementation of most laws is lax in the country. There